

Colons

THE COLON SEPARATES PARTS OF A SENTENCE, WHILE ALSO INDICATING A CLOSE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN THEM.

A colon connects a main clause with another clause, a phrase, or a word. It can be used to provide an explanation or for emphasis, or to introduce a list or quoted material.

SEE ALSO

◀ 70–71 Compound sentences

◀ 96–99 Commas

◀ 100–101 Semicolons

Quotation marks

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Bullet points

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Explanations

A colon shows that what follows a main clause is an explanation of it. The section following the colon can be a main clause, or just a word.

This main clause provides an explanation of what her secret is.

They know her secret: She is obsessed with socks.

Emphasis

A colon can be used to emphasize a point in a text, by causing the reader to pause before reading that point.

The single word emphasizes that she's interested in only one thing.

She thinks about one thing: socks.

Lists

A colon is also used to introduce a list. The section preceding the colon should be a complete statement, but the section following the colon can be just a simple list of things.

Her socks have the following patterns:
striped, spotted, and paisley.

This is the introduction to the list.

The items in the list follow the colon.

The colon is also used in math for **ratios** or **scales**. For example, **3:1** means a ratio of **three to one**.

GLOSSARY

Clause A grammatical unit that contains a subject and a verb. Sentences are made up of one or more clauses.

Main clause A clause that makes complete sense on its own.

Subordinate clause A clause that provides additional information but depends on the main clause for it to make sense.